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Tactical dilemma: Smriti Mandhana and Harmanpreet Kaur run between the wickets during India's Women's T20 World Cup campaign. India's batting depth is unquestioned, but finding the optimal order remains a key challenge. AP

three in all three matches and finished as India's second-highest run-scorer with 119 runs, just one behind Harmanpreet.

There is a strong argument in favour of that approach. The one-drop position is where Jemimah has batted most regularly in T20 cricket, and it is also where she bats for Delhi Capitals in the Women's Premier League.

The counterargument is that placing Jemimah between Smriti and Harmanpreet could leave India with three consecutive batters who prefer to settle in before accelerating. That risks periods of stagnation, particularly when setting totals or chasing large targets against stronger opposition.

Yastika, meanwhile, has shown she can start quickly, although her scoring rate tends to dip as her innings progresses. This was most evident in the second T20I against England, when India added 36 runs from 33 balls before she was retired out in an ultimately unsuccessful chase.

Since Jan 1, 2024 – At No. 3

Player	Inn	Runs	Avg.	S/R
Yastika	4	155	51.66	126.01
Jemimah	24	552	27.60	128.07

Speaking at a roundtable with the media ahead of the T20 World Cup, former England captain Nasser Hussain threw his weight behind Yastika for the number three role, saying, "Her strike rate is excellent, she's a real boundary hitter. I quite

Who'd be a number three?

There are plenty of certainties in this space. Smriti and Shafali have compiled an extensive body of work to cement themselves as the opening pair, while Harmanpreet is generally settled at number four.

There has also been some discussion about whether Richa should move up the order, with Harmanpreet even saying she would "love to send her from ball one" after India's tournament opener against Pakistan. However, her 17-ball 34 in

that match typified the role she now plays in the second half of an innings.

Instead, the biggest question appears to be who will occupy the number three and five positions. Against Pakistan, Jemimah occupied the number three role and made one from seven balls, while Yastika sat out and Bharti Fulmali batted at five.

This represented something of a strategic pivot. In the pre-tournament series against England, Yastika batted at number